

Understanding Philosophy Syllabus

Autumn Semester, 2025

Department	Social Studies	Credits	2	Instructor	Koo, Bon Hyuk	Classroom	3204
Subject	Understanding Philosophy	Class Hours/Wk	2	Office(e-mail)		Attendees	
				Hyeongsulgwan 3105-ho (bonhyukkoo@ksa.hs.kr)		2nd year	

1. Course Description

Course Objectives
In this course, students will philosophically engage with the questions of how, as cognitive agents experiencing and living in the world, we can attain knowledge about the world and human beings and how we ought to live. In the process, students will firmly establish the foundational understanding of metaphysics, epistemology and ethics in the Western philosophy tradition, and attain the ability to philosophize that they can apply to new problems as well in a creative and synthetic manner. Also, weekly discussions will enhance students' ability to build sophisticated concepts and arguments as well as skills in communication and understanding.
Contents
• What is philosophy? - Understand what philosophy is as an academic discipline and consider its meaning and value. • What can we know? - Learn various arguments related to scepticism through the writings of Descartes and Hume among others, and investigate the justificatory foundation and limits of human knowledge. • What exists? - Learn about the realism/anti-realism debates in metaphysics and ontology to establish the foundation of analytical thinking and synthetic approach applicable from the humanities to art and sciences. • How ought we live? - Examine diverse ethical theories ranging from the ancient to our contemporary theories and critically assess their plausibility. - Find out how the ethical theories can be applied to ethical problems that we encounter in life.

2. Text & References

Text: Materials to be distributed for each class

Helpful references: - Russell, B. (1912) The Problems of Philosophy, London: Williams and Norgate; New York: Henry Holt and Company. (Text available for free on www.gutenberg.org and also in the [KSA library](#))

- Dimmock, M and Fisher, A. (2017) Ethics for A-level, Open Book Publishers. (Text available for free on <https://www.openbookpublishers.com/books/10.11647/obp.0125>)
- Law, Stephen (2003) The Philosophy Gym: 25 Short Adventures in Thinking
- Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy <plato.stanford.edu>

3. Core Competencies

Core competencies						
Self-directed growth	Critical thinking	Collaboration	Social-cultural awareness	Insight	Creative thinking	Complex communication
- Enhancement of understanding of general themes in philosophy - Cultivation of critical and analytical abilities regarding concepts, theories, and arguments - Development of new arguments, perspectives, and ideas based on analysis - Improvement of collaboration and communication skills - Growth through setting personal learning goals, seeking necessary information, planning and carrying out the learning process, and reflecting on it						

4. Grading

4.1 The grade will be given according to total points.

Individual Presentation	Tasks	Mid-term Essay	Final Exam	Attendance & Attitude	Total	Remarks
20	20	20	30	10	100%	

4.2 Descriptions of grading

- Report evaluation is based on an accurate understanding of the relevant content, and assesses the logic, structure, and validity of the student's independent and critical reflection on philosophical questions.
- Individual presentations require the student to select a philosophical topic of personal interest, submit an outline, receive feedback from the teacher, prepare accordingly, and then present.
- Assignments and class attitude are evaluated on the quality of submitted work as well as the level of engagement and active participation in class, discussions, and presentations.
- All submissions must be uploaded to Google Classroom before the deadline (late submissions will be penalized) and must be in docx format.
- For all coursework submitted for evaluation, students must also submit a declaration of academic integrity. Plagiarism is considered a serious violation of academic honesty and standards, and will be strictly sanctioned. The inclusion of content generated by generative AI in submitted work is likewise prohibited, as it does not align with the educational objectives of this course.

4.3 Competency-based grading of the mid-term essay and the individual presentation

This is a separate grading system *in addition to* the above grading, with the purpose of providing the student with a more detailed feedback to help the student develop further.

Domain	Competency	Relevant weeks	Assessment material	Evaluator
Self-directed growth	- Select an appropriate report or presentation topic based on one's intellectual curiosity and understanding, and draft an outline grounded in background research. - Locate and comprehend the necessary literature based on feedback on the outline, and complete the report or presentation. - Submit the final work within the given deadline.	All	Final essay and individual presentation (12-15 minutes presentation, 10 minutes QnA)	Teacher
Critical thinking	- Through incorporating feedback and further research, one can develop arguments in a more diverse and/or rigorous manner. - One can derive the most plausible conclusion from the appropriate evidence gathered.	All	As above	Teacher
Insight	Identify key propositions, reasons, or arguments, and analyze or refute them.	All	As above	Teacher
Creative thinking	- Identify new examples, arguments, or counterarguments regarding a philosophical topic or theory. - Discover new perspectives, arguments, or claims through integration or comparison with other fields.	All	As above	Teacher

Competency-Based Assessment Rubric

- **Emerging:** The student begins to grasp the concept of the specific competency and attempts to apply it.
- **Developing:** The student has a partial understanding of the competency and achieves limited success.
- **Proficient:** The student demonstrates internalized understanding and skills related to the competency and achieves considerable success.
- **Mastery:** The student has fully internalized the understanding and skills related to the competency and demonstrates achievement at the level fully expected of the evaluation group.

Further information

Students with outstanding academic achievement will be recommended for a subject excellence award. Core competencies will be included in the subject-specific records, along with detailed abilities related to course activities, performance assessments, participation in learning activities, and overall attitude. However, students with poor academic attitude or attendance will be excluded.

For a missed examination, if it is not possible to calculate a basis score, the average score of performance assessments will be used as the basis score for the credited grade. (※ For the proportion of credited scores, refer to the Academic Performance Management Regulations.)

Exception: In accordance with Article 10, Clause 3 of the Academic Performance Management Regulations ("Regardless of whether a basis score can be calculated, if deemed necessary by the

course instructor, a separate written examination may be administered to absent students upon consultation with the Undergraduate Committee”) (<Amended March 11, 2025>), a separate written examination may be administered.

5. Lecture schedules

Week	Lectures contents	Remarks
Week 01	What is philosophy? / Descartes and the cogito argument	A general overview of the subject
Week 02	What do I know? (1)	Scepticism about the external world
Week 03	What do I know? (2)	Hume and the problem of induction
Week 04	What exists?	Realism and anti-realism about mathematics
Week 05	How ought we live? (1)	Egoism
Week 06	How ought we live? (2)	moral relativism
Week 07	How ought we live? (3)	Utilitarianism and consequentialism
Week 08	Chuseok	
Week 09	Mid-term examination week	
Week 10	How ought we live? (4)	Kantian ethics
Week 11	How ought we live? (5)	Aristotle and virtue ethics
Week 12	Individual Presentation and discussion (1)	
Week 13	Individual Presentation and discussion (2)	
Week 14	Individual Presentation and discussion (3)	
Week 15	Individual Presentation and discussion (4)	
Week 16	Supplementary lecture week	
Week 17	Final examination	